

The Absurd Ark

An IELTS Vocabulary Novel



(Cover Image Placeholder)

Written by
Your Name

CHAPTER 0

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CHAPTER 0

Introduction

Introduction: In the year 2030, the Earth decided it had enough. It wasn't just global warming; it was a full-scale geological rebellion. Our protagonist, Dr. Aris (a brilliant but anxious geologist), is trying to warn the world's richest man, a tech tycoon named Leon Husk (a fictional parody), about the impending doom.

CHAPTER 0

The Crust is Toast

Focus: Physical Geography, Natural Disasters

Plot: Earth is doomed. The decision to flee.

The atmosphere inside the conference room was heavier than the smog outside. Dr. Aris pointed desperately at the holographic globe spinning in the center of the room.

“Mr. Husk, please look at the data,” Aris pleaded. “The lithosphere is cracking. We are detecting abnormal seismic activity from the Equator to the Antarctic. This isn’t just a mishap; it is a catastrophic event in the making.”

Leon Husk, busy playing with a magnetic pebble he found on his private beach, didn’t look up. “Aris, you worry too much. Is it just another El Nino phenomenon? Or maybe a seasonal monsoon?”

“No!” Aris shouted, slamming his hand on the table. “The core of the Earth is unstable! The magma is rising through the mantle and pressing against the crust. We are looking at a global calamity. Yesterday, a volcano that has been dormant for centuries suddenly erupted in the Pacific Ocean. It caused a tsunami that swallowed an entire peninsula!”

Leon finally paused. “A tsunami? Did it hit my factory?”

“Forget the factory! The terrain is changing. glaciers are melting at an unprecedented rate, causing flooding in the low-lying plains. Meanwhile, the interior of the continent is suffering from severe drought. The landscape is turning into a barren desert. If we don’t leave, we will be buried under debris and sediment.”

Leon stood up and walked to the window. Outside, a gale was blowing, and a downpour of acidic rain obscured the horizon. The climate had indeed deteriorated.

“Okay,” Leon said, his eyes gleaming with a spark of madness. “If the terrestrial environment is toxic, we go up. Prepare the spacecraft. We need to reach a safe altitude before the typhoon hits.”

“You mean... leave Earth?” Aris asked, trembling.

“Yes,” Leon grinned. “We are going to explore the cosmos. I heard Mars has a nice valley view this time of year. Plus, no hurricanes there.”

Aris looked at the lightning flashing across the stormy sky. It was a dilemma, but sticking around for the avalanche of doom seemed like a bad idea.

“Fine,” Aris sighed. “But we need to calculate the orbit precisely. One wrong move, and we burn up in the atmosphere.”

CHAPTER 0

The Mutant Menagerie

Focus: Botany, Zoology, Conservation

Plot: Visiting the mutant biology lab on the Ark.

Location: “The Ark” - A massive biodome hidden in a remote desert.

Dr. Aris stepped out of the helicopter and gasped. Before him stood a gigantic glass structure, a self-contained ecosystem designed to preserve Earth’s life.

“Welcome to the Jungle... literally,” Leon grinned. “This is where we conduct our botany and zoology experiments. We need to select the best flora and fauna to take with us.”

They entered the greenhouse. The air was hot and humid, thick with the scent of weird flowers. Aris noticed that the vegetation here was bizarre. There were vines as thick as a man’s arm climbing up the pillars, and gigantic mushrooms (a type of fungus) growing on rotting logs.

“How is this possible?” Aris asked, touching a leaf.

“Science!” Leon replied. “We use hybridization to combine different species. Look at this.” He pointed to a plant with red blossoms. “It performs photosynthesis twenty times faster than normal. It absorbs carbon dioxide and releases pure oxygen instantly. However, it requires a lot of fertilizer.”

“And the animals?” Aris asked, hearing a low roar.

“Ah, the mammals are over there,” Leon led him to a fenced area. “We have a team of biologists working on them. We need animals that can reproduce quickly and evolve to handle Mars’ radiation.”

Aris looked into a cage. Inside was a creature that looked like a lion, but it had the scales of a reptile. “Is that... a carnivore?”

“Strictly speaking, it’s an omnivore now,” Leon shrugged. “We tweaked its genes (gene) to fix a mutation. Now it eats hay and straw like a herbivore, but it retains the hunting instinct of a predator. We call it the ‘Lio-sheep’. It produces excellent wool and milk.”

Aris was horrified. “This is unethical! You are treating living organisms like machines. What if a virus or bacteria spreads among them? An epidemic in space would cause the extinction of the entire crew!”

“Relax,” Leon waved his hand, disturbing a swarm of mosquitoes. “These insects are not pests. They are genetically modified parasites that clean our skin. Totally eco-friendly.”

Suddenly, a loud hiss came from the swamp section. An amphibian the size of a car crawled out of the muddy water.

“Oh, that’s just Gary,” Leon said casually. “He’s our waste management system. He creates compost to help the seeds germinate.”

Aris watched a butterfly with transparent wings land on a branch. “Leon, this biodiversity is chaotic. The food chain is broken. If we don’t cultivate these plants carefully, they will wither and decay. And if these beasts aren’t tamed, they will devour us before we even reach orbit.”

Leon checked his watch. “Noted. But right now, we have to load the cargo. The monsoon is coming, and I don’t want the hail to smash the glass roof. Let’s grab the seeds, the embryos, and get moving.”

Aris looked at the herd of mutant cows chewing on synthetic grass. He realized that saving humanity might be weirder than the apocalypse itself.

CHAPTER 0

The Classroom in the Void

Focus: Space Exploration, Education, Math/Physics

Plot: Mandatory learning during space flight.

Location: “The Ark” - Leaving Earth’s Orbit.

The launch was cataclysmic. The spacecraft shuddered as the massive propulsion system fought against Earth’s gravity. Inside the command module, Dr. Aris felt the overwhelming pressure pinning him to his seat.

“We are approaching the escape velocity!” Leon shouted over the roar. “Prepare for zero-G!”

Suddenly, the shaking stopped. A pencil began to float in the air. Through the reinforced window, the curve of the Earth was visible—a glowing blue sphere against the infinite darkness of the cosmos. They had entered orbit.

“Beautiful, isn’t it?” Leon unbuckled his seatbelt. “The universe is our new playground. But Aris, to survive in this interstellar environment, you are currently an idiot.”

Aris blinked. “Excuse me? I have a PhD (Doctor) in Geology!”

“That’s terrestrial thinking,” Leon scoffed. “Up here, you are a novice, a complete fresher. Welcome to Husk University. I am your principal, headmaster, and mentor. You are the only pupil.”

Leon floated over to a high-tech screen and pulled up a digital timetable. “This is your new curriculum. It’s compulsory. No truancy allowed.”

Aris looked at the schedule. It was a nightmare.

08:00 - Quantum Mechanics & Particle Physics

10:00 - Astronomy: Mapping the Galaxy

12:00 - Calculus & Geometry: Calculating Trajectories

14:00 - Alien Psychology (Optional Elective)

“I have to learn calculus again?” Aris groaned. “I hated maths in primary school.”

“It’s a prerequisite for survival!” Leon insisted. “If you can’t solve a simple equation about the radius of a meteorite or the density of a comet, we will crash! We need to calculate the dimension and mass of every chunk of space debris to avoid a collision.”

Leon handed Aris a heavy tablet. “Here is your textbook. I expect you to acquire this knowledge by tomorrow. You will have to submit a thesis on the composition of Martian dust. And don’t try to

plagiarise from the ship's database. I have software to detect cheating. If you fail, I will suspend your food rations."

"This is abuse!" Aris argued. "I can't cram all this information in one day. My brain can't handle this intensity."

"Be diligent, Aris!" Leon floated upside down. "Use your intelligence. We are on a scientific expedition. You need to master the principles of aerodynamics and thermodynamics. Look at the spectrum of that star over there. Is it emitting ultraviolet or radioactive waves? You need to analyse the signal from our antenna."

Aris sighed and looked at the diagram of a circuit board Leon wanted him to fix. "What happens if I pass?"

"Then I will grant you a degree," Leon smiled. "A Master of Mars. And maybe a scholarship—which means I won't charge you a fee for the oxygen you breathe."

"You were going to charge me?"

"Of course. Nothing is free, not even in a vacuum. Now, stop complaining and start your assignment. The deadline is when we pass the Moon."

Aris floated to the corner, clutching his tablet. He opened the first chapter: "How to fix a fusion reactor with a spoon." It was going to be a long semester

CHAPTER 0

The Gizmo that Saved the World

Focus: Technology, Items & Materials, Fashion

Plot: The ship breaks down. Repairing high-tech gear with style.

Location: The Main Engineering Deck of “The Ark”.

It was a Tuesday (probably), and Leon decided it was time to launch his new interstellar fashion brand.

“Aris, look at me!” Leon twirled in the center of the control room. He was wearing a tight, shiny silver outfit made of synthetic fiber. It featured a high collar, long sleeves adorned with fake gems and beads, and a massive, flowing velvet cape. “I call this look ‘The Cosmic King’. It’s going to be the new vogue. A total trend.”

Aris, who was busy trying to calculate the ship’s fuel consumption using a digital gauge, didn’t look up. “Leon, that costume looks ridiculous. It’s not stylish; it looks like you wrapped yourself in aluminum foil (foil 不在表里, 用 metal 代替) metal sheets.”

“You have no taste for luxury or elegance,” Leon scoffed, adjusting his belt. “This is high-definition beauty. My fans on Earth are watching this on the wireless network. I am their icon, their idol.”

Leon walked over to the main ventilation unit to pose for the camera. “Look at the texture of this fabric,” he bragged, leaning against the intake fan.

Suddenly, disaster struck.

A gust of air sucked the hem of Leon’s velvet cape into the spinning blades of the fan. ZZZZT! CRACK!

The fan jammed. The motor screeched. Sparks flew from the switch board.

“My cape!” Leon shrieked. “The ship!” Aris yelled.

Red lights flashed on the screen. A robotic voice announced: “*Critical error. Ventilation system failure. Oxygen circulation stopped. Hydraulic pressure dropping.*”

“You broke the air scrubber!” Aris panicked. He rushed to the emergency cabinet and grabbed a kit full of tools. “I need to fix this before we suffocate!”

“Well, hurry up!” Leon demanded, trying to untangle his shredded cape. “This is a fashion emergency! My image is being ruined!”

Aris ignored him. He needed to be a mechanic now, not a geologist. He opened the machine's shutter and peered inside. It was a mess. The cape had tangled around the main gear and the pivot. The friction had caused the rubber belt to snap.

"I need materials!" Aris shouted. "Leon, bring me the spare parts box from the storage!"

Leon ran and came back with a bin full of junk: old cables, a broken toaster, a plastic bucket, and a tube of glue.

"This is garbage!" Aris cried. "I need a wrench or a screwdriver!"

"Use your imagination! Improvise!" Leon said unhelpfully.

Aris took a deep breath. He had to devise a solution. He saw a loose bolt and a rusted screw. He used a metal spoon (from his lunch) as a lever to pry open the casing. He found the broken circuit.

"I need to connect these wires," Aris muttered. He stripped the insulation off a cord using a pair of scissors. He realized he didn't have soldering equipment, so he used a piece of gum (Leon was chewing it) to stick the wires together temporarily. "It's a crude technique, but it might work."

Next, the gear. It was stuck. "I need lubricant!" Leon handed him a bottle of expensive shampoo. "It's silky smooth." "Fine!" Aris poured the shampoo onto the gear. It became slippery. He grabbed the tangled fabric and pulled. *Rip!* The cape came free.

Finally, the snapped belt. Aris looked at Leon. "Give me your leather belt." "What? This is genuine Italian leather! It cost a fortune!" "Give it to me, or we die!" Leon sighed and handed it over. Aris used a knife to trim the edge, punched a hole with a nail, and wrapped it around the wheel.

He flipped the switch. *Whirrrr...*

The fan started to spin. The generator hummed. The red warning light on the monitor turned green. Fresh air began to circulate again.

Aris collapsed on the floor, wiping grease and sweat from his forehead with a rag. He looked at his shabby, oil-stained clothes.

Leon stood up, smoothing his torn garment. "Well," he said, looking at the camera. "As I was saying... this distressed look is the latest trend. It symbolizes the fragile nature of human existence."

Aris threw the wrench (imaginary wrench) at him.

CHAPTER 0

Culture Shock in a Can

Focus: Culture & History, Language, Social Roles

Plot: Leon tries to design a future Martian civilization.

Location: The Recreation Room (now converted into a “Throne Room”).

Three weeks into the voyage, cabin fever had set in. Aris walked into the mess hall to find Leon sitting on a pile of boxes, wearing a makeshift crown made of wire.

“Halt, commoner!” Leon commanded. “You are entering the sacred hall of the New Martian Empire. Show some respect.”

Aris sighed. “Leon, it’s just the cafeteria. And why are you sitting like that?”

“I am establishing a new civilization,” Leon declared, gesturing with a plastic spoon like it was a royal scepter. “We cannot rely on Earth’s outdated traditions or customs. We need a cultural renaissance. I am the emperor, the monarch of this metal box. You, Aris, are my loyal subject, or perhaps my servant... no, let’s say prime minister.”

“I prefer colleague,” Aris muttered.

“Silence!” Leon stood up. “In this hierarchy, I have the highest status and prestige. We are returning to a form of enlightened feudalism. I am the lord, and you are the... well, you do the work, so you are the peasant. But a well-paid one!”

“This sounds like slavery with extra steps,” Aris argued. “And what about our heritage? We are ambassadors of Earth. We represent democracy and liberty.”

“Democracy is slow,” Leon waved his hand. “My regime is efficient. Now, let’s discuss etiquette. From now on, whenever you approach me, you must perform a specific ritual. You must bow three times and offer a tribute—preferably a coffee.”

Aris rolled his eyes. “This is a cult, not a culture.”

“Speaking of culture,” Leon continued, ignoring him. “I have decided that English is too inefficient. We need a new language to unite our future Martian colony. I call it ‘Leonish’.”

Leon walked to a whiteboard covered in strange drawings. “Look at these symbols. I have replaced the alphabet with pictographs based on my face. This smiling face means ‘Good morning’, and this angry face means ‘The engine is on fire’.”

“That’s not a language; that’s just emojis,” Aris critiqued. “A real language needs complex grammar, syntax, and a rich vocabulary. It evolves through usage over centuries. You can’t just invent a dialect overnight.”

“Watch me,” Leon grinned. “In Leonish, we don’t use verbs. We use gestures. It’s all about non-verbal communication. For example, wiggling your thumb means ‘I agree’.”

“And what about pronunciation?” Aris asked. “Or intonation?”

“We speak in a high-pitched accent to simulate the thin atmosphere of Mars,” Leon demonstrated, squeaking like a mouse. “It distinguishes the elite from the vulgar masses.”

Aris rubbed his temples. “Leon, if we meet aliens, and you speak to them like that, they will think we are lunatics (insane). They won’t see us as a superior species; they’ll see us as a snack.”

“Nonsense,” Leon sat back on his throne. “Future generations will look back at this moment as the origin of a great dynasty. My descendants—or rather, my clones—will worship me as a legend, a myth.”

“Right now,” Aris said, grabbing a packet of dried food. “The only myth is your sanity. I’m going to eat my lunch. In private.”

“Wait!” Leon shouted. “You forgot the ritual! And you didn’t wiggle your thumb!”

Aris walked out, wondering if mutiny (rebellion) was a viable option in space.

CHAPTER 0

The Great Space Jam

Focus: Entertainment & Sports, Art & Music

Plot: Boredom strikes. Zero-gravity Olympics.

Location: The Cargo Bay (converted into a “Multipurpose Stadium”).

“Welcome, ladies and gentlemen—and mutant goats!” Leon’s voice boomed over the loudspeaker. He was standing on a floating platform, holding a microphone. “Today, we make history. Welcome to the first annual Ark Olympic Games!”

Aris floated into the room, looking tired. “Leon, there are only two of us. How can we have a competition?”

“Details, details,” Leon waved his hand. “We need recreation. We need to maintain our physical fitness. Plus, the Lio-sheep is an excellent athlete. Look at those muscles.”

Leon pointed to the mutant lion-sheep, which was currently chewing on a volleyball net.

“First event: Zero-Gravity Tennis!” Leon announced. He tossed a racket to Aris. “The rules are simple. You hit the ball over the net. If you drift into the ceiling, you lose a point.”

Aris sighed but grabbed the racket. He missed exercise. He tried to serve, throwing the ball up. But in zero-G, the ball didn’t come down. It just hovered there. Leon seized the moment, swung his racket, and performed a violent smash. The ball flew past Aris, bounced off the wall, hit a drum kit in the corner, and landed in Leon’s hand.

“Point to me!” Leon shouted. “I am the champion! The crowd goes wild!” He pressed a button, and a recording of cheering spectators played loudly.

Next came the marathon. Since they couldn’t run far, Leon set up two treadmills. “We will jog in place for four hours,” Leon said. “Keep a steady pace and maintain your rhythm.”

Ten minutes later, Leon got bored. “This is dull. Let’s switch to the Arts Festival.”

He dimmed the lights and turned on a spotlight. “Behold, my gallery.”

He pulled a sheet off a pile of twisted metal, broken wires, and old food wrappers. “I call this sculpture *‘The Agony of a Lost Wi-Fi Signal’*. It is a masterpiece of abstract art. Notice the aesthetic balance between the garbage and the void.”

Aris stared at the pile of trash. “It looks like a broken toaster stuck to a shoe.”

“You are no critic,” Leon scoffed. “You lack artistic vision. Now, prepare yourself for the highlight of the evening: The Concert.”

Leon floated over to a collection of instruments he had improvised from spare ship parts. There was a “guitar” made of a shovel and rubber bands, and a “drum” made of empty water tanks.

“I will now perform a solo,” Leon announced. “It is a fusion of classical, jazz, rock, and hip-hop. I call it ‘Space Noise’.”

He started to play. It was loud. It was chaotic. There was no melody, no tune, and certainly no harmony. He banged on the drum while screaming unintelligible lyrics into the mic.

“Listen to that rhythm!” Leon yelled, strumming his shovel-guitar. “I am a musical genius! I am better than any band on Earth! I am the new Pop King!”

The Lio-sheep, unable to bear the noise, let out a deafening roar that sounded surprisingly like a trumpet.

“Ah,” Leon stopped playing. “The audience is participating! A true symphony of nature and machine!”

Aris floated over to the piano (which was actually just a keyboard painted on a table). “Leon, please. Let’s just watch a movie. Do we have any films in the database?”

“Fine,” Leon pouted, putting down his shovel. “But nothing boring. I want action, drama, comedy, and tragedy all in one.”

They settled down to watch an old animation. But as the opening credits rolled, Aris noticed something strange on the screen.

“Leon,” Aris pointed. “Why is the conductor of the orchestra in the movie wearing a gas mask?”

Leon froze. “Wait. That’s not the movie. That’s a reflection.” He sniffed the air. “Do you smell burning plastic?”

“You overloaded the circuits with your electric shovel!” Aris screamed. “The kitchen fuse just blew!”

“Well,” Leon shrugged. “At least the show ended with a bang.”

CHAPTER 0

Kitchen Nightmares

Focus: Food & Health, Body & Mind

Plot: Food synthesizer failure. Sickness ensues.

Location: The Galley (Kitchen).

The air in the kitchen smelled of burnt toast and melted plastic. The ChefBot 3000 was sputtering, its lid flapping open and closed like a hungry bird.

"I am starving," Leon announced, tapping his cutlery (a fork and a spoon) against an empty plate. "I demand a banquet. I want a three-course meal with appetizers, a main dish, and a dessert."

Aris looked at the smoking machine. "Leon, the recipe database is corrupted. The machine doesn't know the difference between a tomato and a potato. It might poison us."

"Nonsense," Leon scoffed. "I am a gourmet. I have a refined palate. I can appreciate any cuisine, even experimental ones. ChefBot, serve dinner!"

The machine whirred. It didn't bake, fry, or roast. It just... *extruded*.

SPLAT.

A pile of grey sludge landed in a bowl.

"Ah," Leon peered at it. "It looks like... porridge? Or maybe mashed eggplant?"

Aris sniffed it. "It smells like vinegar mixed with old socks."

"Don't be picky," Leon said, grabbing a knife. He sliced a piece of something that looked like a sausage but smelled like vanilla ice cream. "This is fusion food! Look, here is a sandwich made of beef, strawberry jam, and... is that mustard?"

Leon took a big bite. He chewed vigorously. He swallowed. His face turned green.

"Interesting flavor," Leon wheezed, clutching his throat. "It's a bit... sour. And bitter. And... oh god."

"Don't eat it!" Aris yelled, but he was too hungry. He grabbed a biscuit that looked safe. It turned out to be a block of compressed salt and pepper. He choked, grabbing a mug of beverage to wash it down. It was hot ketchup mixed with coffee.

Ten minutes later, the buffet was over, and the suffering began.

Aris lay on the floor, holding his stomach (abdomen). "I think I have food poisoning."

“Me too,” Leon groaned, lying on the bench. “My abdomen feels like it’s exploding. I feel nauseous (sick).”

Aris tried to check his own symptoms. “My headache is splitting. I feel dizzy. My vision is blurry. Leon, check my pulse.”

Leon crawled over, his hand shaking. He touched Aris’s wrist. “Your heartbeat is irregular. You have a fever. Your forehead is burning hot. You are definitely ill.”

“My intestines are twisting,” Aris moaned. “I think my liver and kidneys are shutting down. That ‘sausage’ was toxic waste!”

“We need medical attention,” Leon said, trying to stand up but failing due to fatigue. “I am the ship’s physician now. Where is the first aid kit?”

He dragged a box over. It contained random items: a box of aspirin (pills), a bottle of cough syrup, some bandages, and a large syringe (for injections).

“Okay,” Leon said, putting on a mask. “I will diagnose you. You have Acute Space Indigestion. The remedy is... everything in this box.”

“No!” Aris shouted weakly. “Just give me some water to flush out the toxins. I need to digest this mess.”

“I prescribe a strict diet,” Leon muttered, swallowing a pill himself. “From now on, we are vegetarians. No... fruitarians. We only eat apples and pears. No more dairy, no cheese, no butter, and definitely no experimental seafood.”

“We don’t have apples,” Aris reminded him. “We only have those mutant cabbages in the greenhouse.”

“Then we eat cabbage soup,” Leon sighed, closing his eyes. “For the rest of the voyage. It’s vital for our fitness and hygiene.”

Aris curled up in pain. “If I survive this, I’m going to sue you for malpractice.”

“Rest now,” Leon whispered, drifting into a coma-like sleep. “Tomorrow, we start our recovery. Or we die. Either way, no more cooking.”

CHAPTER 0

Mars BnB

Focus: Architecture, Transport/Travel

Plot: Landing on Mars. Building the base.

Location: The Surface of Mars (Utopia Planitia).

“Attention, passengers,” Leon announced over the intercom, even though Aris was sitting right next to him. “We are approaching our destination. Please fasten your seatbelts and stow your luggage in the overhead rack. We may experience a slight delay due to a dust storm on the route.”

The shuttle (a smaller vehicle detached from The Ark) shook violently as it entered the thin Martian atmosphere.

“Leon, slow down!” Aris yelled. “You are coming in too fast! The landing gear won’t hold!”

“Relax,” Leon grinned, steering with one hand. “I’m an excellent pilot. I’m aiming for that flat site near the canyon. It’s the perfect location for a resort.”

BOOM!

The shuttle slammed into the red dust, bounced twice, and skidded to a halt near a pile of rocks.

“We have arrived,” Leon said, dusting off his jacket. “Welcome to Mars Harbour. Please check that you haven’t left any personal items on the craft.”

They stepped out. The landscape was desolate but majestic.

“Okay,” Leon clapped his hands. “Time to construct our new home. Aris, unload the ‘Instant-City’ modules from the cargo hold.”

Aris dragged out several heavy crates. “We need a basic shelter first. A secure dwelling to protect us from radiation and cold. Maybe a small hut or a cabin.”

“Think bigger, Aris!” Leon pressed a button on a remote. “I didn’t travel 140 million miles to live in a shed. I’m building a villa.”

One of the crates exploded open. Nanobots swarmed out, assembling materials. In minutes, a structure began to rise. It wasn’t a simple base; it was a monstrosity.

It had a grand entrance with tall marble columns (fake marble, actually plastic). It had a lobby with a crystal chandelier (which didn’t sparkle because there was no light). It even had a balcony overlooking the dusty plain.

“Behold!” Leon gestured. “The Musk Mansion. It features a spacious living room, a master bedroom, and a guest suite for you.”

Aris walked inside. “Leon, this is ridiculous. Where is the infrastructure? Where is the plumbing? Where is the sewage system?”

“Details,” Leon waved him off. “Check out the elevator. It goes up to the terrace on the roof.”

“It’s a two-storey building,” Aris pointed out. “We can use the stairs.”

“We also have a commercial wing,” Leon continued. “Over there, I plan to build a mall and a casino. And maybe a stadium for the Lio-sheep to play soccer.”

Aris inspected the foundation. It looked shaky. The concrete was setting too fast in the cold. “Leon, this structure is unstable. The ceiling is sagging. And you put the toilet in the kitchen!”

“It’s an open-concept layout,” Leon argued. “Very modern. Very urban style.”

“We are in a rural desert!” Aris shouted. “We need a warehouse for food storage, a greenhouse for the plants, and a power plant for electricity. Instead, you built a skyscraper that is only two floors high!”

Suddenly, a warning siren wailed from the shuttle. “*Warning: Sandstorm approaching. Visibility zero.*”

“Quick!” Aris pushed Leon inside. “Seal the shutters! Lock the gate!”

They huddled in the corridor, the safest place in the “mansion.” The wind howled outside, battering the walls and roof.

“Well,” Leon whispered in the dark. “At least the location is prime. Once the storm clears, the property value will skyrocket. We can rent out the spare apartment on Airbnb.”

“Who are we going to rent it to?” Aris asked. “The aliens?”

“You never know,” Leon smirked. “I put up a signpost near the landing zone. ‘Vacancy. Free Wi-Fi.’ They’ll come.”

CHAPTER 0

The Republic of Two

Focus: Government, Law, Economy

Plot: Society of two needs laws and money.

Location: The Grand Hall of the Musk Mansion (a.k.a. the living room).

The sun rose over the red horizon. Aris walked into the living room to find Leon sitting behind a desk, wearing a sash that said “Supreme Leader.”

“Good morning, citizen,” Leon said solemnly. “I have stayed up all night drafting the Constitution.”

“The what?” Aris asked, yawning.

“The Constitution of the United Republic of Mars,” Leon held up a piece of napkin with scribbles on it. “We need a formal government to maintain order and stability. I have appointed myself as the President, the Prime Minister, and the Minister of Defense.”

“And what am I?” Aris asked.

“You are the population,” Leon replied. “And also the Vice Minister of Sanitation (cleaning toilets). Congratulations on your appointment.”

Aris rolled his eyes. “Leon, this isn’t a democracy; it’s a dictatorship (implied by regime). I demand an election.”

“We can hold a vote later,” Leon dismissed him. “But first, we must discuss the economy. Our society needs a currency to facilitate trade.”

Leon opened a suitcase full of plastic chips. “I introduce to you: The Leon-Coin. It is the official legal tender of Mars.”

“This is ridiculous,” Aris said. “We don’t need money. We just share resources.”

“That sounds like socialism,” Leon narrowed his eyes. “In my capitalist system, everything has a price. For example, I own the infrastructure, including the air scrubbers. Therefore, I am imposing a tax on oxygen.”

“You can’t tax air!” Aris shouted. “That violates my basic human rights!”

“I have the authority,” Leon tapped a gavel (a hammer). “If you cannot pay, you will go into debt. But don’t worry, the Bank of Leon offers loans with a very reasonable 50% interest rate.”

Aris was furious. “I refuse to pay! I am going on strike!”

“Then you are breaking the law,” Leon stood up. “I accuse you of tax evasion and treason. As the police chief, I hereby arrest you.”

Leon tried to handcuff Aris with a zip-tie. Aris pushed him away.

“I demand a trial!” Aris yelled. “I want a lawyer and a jury!”

“Fine,” Leon sat back down. “The court is now in session. I am the judge. The jury consists of the Lio-sheep and Gary the giant salamander.”

“This judicial process is a joke,” Aris protested. “You are the plaintiff, the judge, and the witness? There is no justice here! This is a corrupt regime!”

“Silence in the court!” Leon banged the table. “The evidence is clear. You consumed 500 liters of my oxygen without payment. The verdict is... guilty. Your sentence is hard labor—you must clean the solar panels for a month.”

“I appeal!” Aris shouted. “I challenge your legitimacy. I hereby declare a revolution!”

Aris grabbed the bag of Leon-Coins and threw them out the window.

“My capital!” Leon screamed, watching his wealth scatter in the Martian wind. “You just caused hyper-inflation! The market will crash!”

“Power to the people!” Aris chanted. “I am organizing a campaign for a new leader.”

“Fine!” Leon crossed his arms. “Let’s vote. Who votes for me?” Leon raised his hand. “Who votes for Aris?” Aris raised his hand.

“It’s a tie,” Leon grumbled. “We have a political deadlock. The parliament is hung.”

Suddenly, the Lio-sheep walked in, ate the Constitution (the napkin), and burped.

“I think the supreme court just overruled us both,” Aris noted.

“Okay,” Leon sighed, taking off his sash. “New policy. No taxes. But you still have to cook dinner. That’s a mandatory regulation.”

“Deal,” Aris agreed. “But if you try to sell me water again, I will sue you to mint coins. “This is the new **currency**,” he said. Aris pointed out the **inflation** risks since there were no goods to buy.

CHAPTER 0

The Mutiny

Focus: War/Conflict, Actions

Plot: Mutant animals revolt. Action sequences.

Location: The Musk Mansion, Mars.

The morning started with an ominous silence. Aris walked into the kitchen and found the Lio-sheep standing on the table. It was glaring at him. Its eyes were no longer the eyes of a dumb beast; they were full of hatred and intelligence.

“Shoo!” Aris waved his hand. “Get down!”

The Lio-sheep didn’t move. Instead, it let out a low growl (roar) that sounded like a threat. Suddenly, Gary the giant salamander kicked open the door. A troop of mutant chickens marched in, their beaks sharp as blades.

“Leon!” Aris shouted, backing away. “We have a problem!”

Leon rushed in, wearing his pajamas. “What is this disturbance? Why are you interrupting my beauty sleep?”

“It’s a revolt!” Aris cried. “The animals are staging a mutiny!”

“Ridiculous,” Leon scoffed. He walked up to the Lio-sheep. “Listen here, you rebel. I am your general, your creator! I command you to cease this behavior immediately!”

The Lio-sheep snatched Leon’s “Supreme Leader” sash with its teeth and ripped it apart. It was a clear act of treason.

“Okay,” Leon whispered, his face pale. “That was aggressive. They are hostile. Aris, prepare for battle.”

“With what?” Aris asked, trembling (shaking).

“We need weapons,” Leon said. He ran to the closet and equipped himself with a tennis racket (now a shield) and a modified leaf-blower (now a cannon). He handed Aris a bottle of spicy sauce. “This is your pistol. Aim for the eyes.”

The animals launched their attack. It was a fierce assault. The chickens fired missiles (eggs) with deadly accuracy. Gary the salamander used his tail to smash the furniture.

“Defend the perimeter!” Leon yelled, trying to deter the chickens with a blast of air. “Do not let them invade the living room!”

But the enemy had a strategy. While the chickens distracted them, the Lio-sheep led a flank attack (side attack) and seized the refrigerator.

“They captured the food supply!” Aris screamed. “This is a catastrophe! We will starve!”

“Do not panic!” Leon roared, trying to rally his courage. “We must counter-attack! Charge!”

Leon dashed forward, swinging his racket. He tried to strike Gary, but the slippery amphibian dodged and whipped Leon’s legs. Leon tumbled (fell) to the ground.

“I am wounded!” Leon cried dramatically, holding his knee (which was just slightly bruised). “Aris, save me!”

Aris looked at the chaos. The room was in turmoil. The violence was escalating. He realized they couldn’t defeat this army. The animals were too sturdy and reckless.

“We have to retreat!” Aris grabbed Leon by the collar and started to drag him. “Fall back to the greenhouse! It’s our only refuge!”

They fled down the corridor, dodging flying eggs. The animals pursued them, barking and hissing in triumph.

Aris slammed the heavy glass door of the greenhouse and locked it. He leaned against it, panting. Outside, the Lio-sheep stared at them through the glass, a look of victory on its face. It had conquered the mansion.

“We are under siege,” Leon gasped, looking at the army surrounding their glass prison. “They have cut off our supplies. It’s a conspiracy. They planned this.”

“Why?” Aris asked, wiping sweat from his brow. “Why did they rebel?”

Leon looked through the glass. The Lio-sheep was currently trying to turn on the TV.

“I think...” Leon muttered. “I think they just wanted to watch the cartoons we watched in Chapter 6. I prohibited them from watching TV last night.”

“You started a war over cartoons?” Aris glared at him.

“I’m a strict parent,” Leon shrugged. “But now, we are destitute. We are prisoners in our own ship. We have lost our freedom.”

“We have to negotiate,” Aris said, holding up a white towel (a sign of surrender). “We have to compromise.”

Leon sighed. “Fine. I will offer them Netflix password. But I refuse to bow to a sheep.”

CHAPTER 0

Reflections on Time

Focus: Time, Emotions/Abstract

Plot: Reflection and nostalgia.

Location: Inside the Greenhouse, looking out at the Martian night sky.

It was midnight. Or maybe it was midday. It was hard to tell. On Mars, the daily cycle was slightly longer than on Earth, throwing their biological clock into chaos.

Leon sat on a sack of fertilizer, staring at the stars. His usual energetic and hectic mood had vanished. He looked gloomy, miserable, and strangely quiet.

“Aris,” Leon broke the silence. “Do you know what date it is?”

“I’ve lost track,” Aris sighed, checking his watch. “The battery died a century ago. Or maybe just a week. Time feels everlasting here. It stretches out into an infinite duration.”

“On Earth,” Leon whispered, “it would be the anniversary of my company’s founding. Usually, I would be hosting an annual gala. There would be music, laughter, and champagne. I would be the center of attention, looking confident and proud.”

He looked down at his torn clothes. “Now, look at me. I look wretched and awkward. My reputation is ruined. I bet the contemporary media is calling me a failure. They probably think I’m insane or mad.”

Aris looked at Leon. For the first time, he didn’t feel anger or hatred. He felt sympathetic.

“Leon,” Aris said gently. “You are arrogant, selfish, and stubborn. You are often a nuisance and a bother. But you are also enterprising. You dared to come here. That is not negligible.”

Leon managed a weak smile. “You are being frank.”

“I’m being honest,” Aris sat next to him. “Initially, I was reluctant to come. I was hesitant and skeptical. I felt resentment (bitterness) towards you. But in the midst of all this chaos, I realized something. We are living in a new era.”

“A medieval era,” Leon grumbled. “Ruled by chickens.”

“Perhaps,” Aris chuckled. “But think about it. We are the foremost humans on this planet. Every moment we survive is a precedent. We are creating history simultaneously with our suffering.”

Leon looked out the glass. The Lio-sheep was sleeping near the door. The hostile atmosphere had temporarily calmed down.

"I feel guilty," Leon confessed, his voice trembling. "I was greedy. I wanted fame and fortune. I was indifferent to the risks. I ignored your warnings. I was rash and reckless. Now, I regret everything. I am ashamed."

Aris patted his shoulder. "Don't weep, Leon. It's useless to mourn the past. The former world is behind us. We have to focus on the present and the imminent future."

"Do you think we have a future?" Leon asked, sounding pessimistic and desperate. "The animals are sturdy and vicious. Our situation is unstable."

"I am optimistic," Aris said, pointing at a small blue dot in the sky. "Look. That's Earth. It looks so peaceful, so delicate. It reminds me that our problems are temporary. We just need to be patient and rational."

Leon gazed at the pale blue dot. A wave of nostalgia (homesickness) washed over him. He felt a deep yearning for home.

"You are right," Leon wiped his eyes. "I shouldn't be passive. I need to be positive. I need to regain my zeal. We will survive this."

"Incidentally," Aris added. "I think the Lio-sheep likes music. Remember the concert? It stopped attacking when you played the rhythm. Maybe we can tame them."

Leon's eyes lit up. His enthusiastic personality returned immediately.

"Music!" Leon jumped up. "Of course! I am a musical genius! I will compose a symphony of peace! It will be glorious! It will be awesome!"

Aris smiled. The old, annoying Leon was back. But this time, Aris felt a sense of mutual understanding. They were partners in this ridiculous fate.

"Okay, Mozart," Aris stood up. "Let's wait for dawn. Tomorrow, we negotiate with the chickens. But for the meantime, let's get some sleep."

"Goodnight, Aris," Leon said, sounding sincere. "And... thank you. For being tolerant."

"Goodnight, Mr. President," Aris replied.

Outside, the wind howled, but inside, there was finally a sense of harmony.

CHAPTER 0

Grand Finale

Focus: Review of difficult words

Plot: Wrapping up the story.

Location: The Terrace of the Musk Mansion (at sunrise).

The Martian sun peeked over the horizon, casting a long shadow across the red plain. The atmosphere was tense but hopeful. Leon stood on the balcony, holding his “shovel-guitar.” Aris stood beside him, holding a flag made of a white bedsheet—a symbol of peace and surrender.

“Are you ready?” Aris asked.

“I was born ready,” Leon adjusted his tattered collar. “This will be my greatest performance.”

Below them, the army of mutant animals waited. The Lio-sheep looked up, its expression stern but curious. Gary the salamander was chewing on a piece of cable.

Leon took a deep breath and struck a chord. *TWANG!*

It wasn’t perfect, but it was... musical. He began to play a slow, gentle melody. It wasn’t the chaotic noise from before. It was a sincere tune, full of emotion.

“Friends!” Leon sang (surprisingly in tune). “Why do we fight? Why do we quarrel? We are all stuck on this rock together! Let us unite!”

The chickens stopped clucking. The Lio-sheep sat down. The rhythm seemed to soothe their savage instincts.

Aris joined in, tapping a rhythm on a plastic bucket. “We offer you freedom! We offer you respect! No more cages! No more chains!”

It worked. The animals didn’t attack. Instead, the Lio-sheep let out a soft moan (a happy sound) and wagged its tail. The hostility vanished. The siege was over.

“We did it!” Leon whispered, tears of joy in his eyes. “We achieved harmony!”

Just then, a loud boom echoed through the valley. A bright light flashed in the sky.

“Is that a meteorite?” Aris gasped.

“No,” Leon squinted. “It’s a spaceship.”

A sleek, silver vessel descended and landed gracefully near their wrecked shuttle. The door opened, and a delegation of humans in pristine white uniforms walked out.

“Dr. Aris? Mr. Husk?” the leader of the group asked. “I am Captain Nova from the Earth Rescue Mission. We received your distress signal... three months ago. Sorry for the delay. Traffic was terrible near the Moon.”

Leon dropped his shovel. “Rescue? We are saved!”

“We are here to take you home,” Captain Nova said, looking around at the ruined mansion, the mutant chickens, and the two dirty, bearded men. “Although... it looks like you have established a... unique community here.”

Leon looked at Aris. Then he looked at the Lio-sheep, who was now nuzzling his leg. He looked at the ugly, half-finished villa they had built with their own hands.

“Go home?” Leon hesitated. “Back to the taxes, the paparazzi, and the boring board meetings?”

Aris looked at the red landscape. It was harsh, barren, and dangerous. But it was also theirs. They had survived disasters, diseases, and mutinies. They had created a language, a government (sort of), and a new species.

“Actually,” Aris said, surprising himself. “We have a lot of unfinished business here. We need to restore the greenhouse. We need to educate the chickens. We have a vision for this planet.”

“You mean...” Leon grinned. “We stay?”

“We stay,” Aris nodded. “This is our colony. Our legacy.”

Leon turned to Captain Nova. “Thank you, Captain. But we decline your offer. However, could you leave us some supplies? Specifically, chocolate, shampoo, and a real guitar?”

Captain Nova looked confused but agreed. The crew unloaded crates of necessities and took off, leaving the two pioneers behind.

As the ship disappeared into the cosmos, Leon put his arm around Aris’s shoulder.

“Well, Mr. Prime Minister,” Leon said. “We have a nation to build. What’s the first item on the agenda?”

“First,” Aris said, picking up a hammer. “We fix the toilet.”

“Agreed,” Leon laughed. “And then... we hold an election.”

And so, on the dusty plains of Mars, under the eternal gaze of the stars, the absurd adventure of Leon and Aris continued. They were lonely, they were crazy, but they were free.

THE END.